

Harry Potter. A gradual color transition towards Gothic

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Introduction

Harry Potter certainly needs no presentation. Even after twenty years from the release of the first movie, the series still has millions of fans all over the world. The story is centered upon this young wizard whose parents were killed by Lord Voldemort. Harry lives a gloomy childhood in the muggle (non-magic) world, until he begins to study at Hogwarts, a school of wizardry. He makes friends, in particular Ron Weasley and Hermione Granger. Even though his life is continually marked by tragedies, he becomes a great wizard, able to fulfill his destiny and destroy his own enemy. The story originates from the seven books written by J.K. Rowling and published between 1997 and 2007. The movies were distributed by the Warner Bros company between 2001 and 2011, with Daniel Radcliffe, Rupert Grint and Emma Watson playing the roles of the main protagonists.

I have selected this topic because I have grown up with the series. I love the movies as much as I love the books: as many others, Harry Potter introduced me to the world of literature. When I first read the books I was very young and I didn't read that much. Today, I am a devoted reader and I have to thank J.K. Rowling for letting me appreciate the power of a good story. This is a good opportunity to write about Harry, but also to write in English. In fact, I am also considering writing my final thesis in English. Moreover, all the articles that I have found are written in English.

This essay is divided in two parts: the preamble has the aim to present the gradual transition of the movies towards the gothic genre, with the introduction of monstrous creatures and settings that get darker through the series. There's also a brief explanation of color: how it is perceived and most importantly which connotations it's related to. Finally, the two aspects can join each other: in fact, the gothic transition is strictly related to the use of color in the Harry Potter series.

In the second part, we switch from theory to practice with seven case studies. In each case study, there is a comparison between the same scene, presented in the first and last movies. The general aim is to demonstrate how the colors get darker as the story evolves and Harry grows up. I have taken the images from the [Internet Movie Database](#) and put them in Figma, a collaborative interface design tool, in rectangles of the same size (1920x1080), in order to get a sense of visual coherence. Above each rectangle there's a color palette, consisting of six colors. I have used the instrument "pick color" to get the most relevant colors from the images inside of the palettes. There's also a caption for each color, defining for which area, object or person that color is related to.

Part one. A theoretical analysis

Gothic encounters the world of Harry Potter

Gothic could be described as a writing of excess, that appears in the eighteenth century. The gloomy and mysterious atmospheres evoke a sense of terror. Specters and monsters populate Gothic landscapes as suggestive figures of imagined and realistic threats. These landscapes are often desolate, alienating and full of menace. Widely recurrent is the castle: decaying, bleak and full of hidden passages. The castle of Hogwarts is the place in which the Harry Potter movies are mainly set, as the protagonists follow their magical lessons during the seven years of school. It's very important to underline that the castle is always presented as the place in which Harry feels at home. There's a sense of protection in Hogwarts: it's full of powerful wizards like the headmaster Dumbledore, which is kind of a paternal figure to Harry. The castle is very big and full of magical elements, like the moving stairs or living paintings. Even the ghosts that live at Hogwarts aren't an actual threat. However, from the very beginning we understand that the castle is not that safe. In *Harry Potter and the Philosopher's Stone* (2001), the protagonists find a three-headed dog in a locked room and are attacked by a troll. In addition, in *Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets* (2002), a basilisk begins to use the pipes of the castle in order to attack some of the students.

According to the critic Robert Mighall, "The Gothic is a process, not an essence". In fact, the story of Harry Potter begins as a tale about magic, friendship and love. However, there's a significant change during the series: in particular, starting from *Harry Potter and the Prisoner of Azkaban* (2004). For instance, Harry's encounter with the Dementor on the train to Hogwarts is quite scary. The whole scene has the aim to provoke anxiety: the rain, the train that stops, the lights that go out and the suspenseful music. Finally, the Dementor appears, showing only a skeleton hand: the creature, portrayed as a hooked dark being, could be related to the medieval representation of death. Death is introduced from the very beginning, when we learn about the assassination of Harry's parents by Lord Voldemort. Nevertheless, this event is related to the past, a tragedy that has become a memory. Harry is safe now, surrounded by a magical world. It's by the end of *Harry Potter and the Goblet of Fire* (2005) that death becomes a dominant theme. In the first sequence of the movie, the murder of a muggle (non-magician) is shown. Even though we soon discover that it's just a nightmare made by Harry, the sequence works as an omen for what happens at the end. In fact, Cedric Diggory, a student of Hogwarts, is killed in a graveyard by the same Lord Voldemort. Even the end of the next two movies is marked by death: in *Harry Potter and the Order of the Phoenix* (2007), Harry's godfather dies in a duel against a Death-eater (follower of Voldemort), while in *Harry Potter and the Half-Blood Prince* (2009), Dumbledore dies by the hand of one of his own teachers: Severus Snape.

Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows: Part one (2010) is the darkest of the series. In one of the first scenes, we see Lord Voldemort and his followers gathered around the suspended body of Professor Burbage. The sequence ends with the body being given as a meal to the snake Nagini. This opening introduces us to a whole different movie. It's important to underline that this is the only case in which we don't actually see the castle of Hogwarts. Harry, Ron and Hermione begin a journey in which they don't actually know where they are going. When the castle returns, in *Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows: Part two* (2011), it's very different from the one that we remember. It's now under the guidance of Severus Snape and other Death-eaters. It seems bigger, darker, full of silence and frightened students. This is the culmination of the process of gothicization that has transformed the school, that magical place presented at the beginning, in a castle of horrors.

Color: perception, culture and meaning

Color information is related to the wavelengths of light that get to the retina. When a source of illumination (natural or artificial) strikes an object, it reflects some of the wavelengths back toward the observer's eye. It's important to underline that light and dark are qualities of the colored surface, not of light. Physical light is neither light nor dark, it is merely more or less intense. The incoming wavelengths are captured by three types of cone photoreceptors: short, middle and long. How the wavelengths are grouped into color categories requires understanding the neural processes that occur in the retina and along the visual system. Opponent process theory provides an explanation of color contrast. For instance, it shows that yellow on a green background appears more reddish. The same yellow appears more saturated on a blue background and less saturated on a yellow background. This means that triplets of cone responses are insufficient to specify the colors we perceive. In fact, simultaneous color contrast demonstrates that the perception of color doesn't depend only on the cone responses activated by that surface, but also on surrounding cone response triplets.

As we have understood, colors are difficult to be categorized from a perceptual point of view. However, they also differentiate with respect to culture and language. Actually, we have different color classifications: for example, Berlin & Kay (1991) determined that English speakers have eleven basic color terms that correspond to eleven categories. This is impressive if we think that there are more than 3,000 English color words. Similarly, French has over 200 color words that can be reduced to the same basic eleven colors. The authors wanted to determine a basic subset of color names that people would universally relate to the same regions of color space. This supports the Universalist's idea that all cultures have the same perceptual categorization of color space. Even if the number of basic color names currently available in any given culture is eleven, there are some differences. It's also interesting to specify that less technologically developed cultures often have fewer basic color names and as cultures evolve they seem to add additional color-terms to their vocabulary.

The symbolism of color has a long history of study. Many researchers have tried to define some systematic patterns of meaning. For example, according to Levy (1984), cool colors are soothing, while warm colors stimulate. However, the meaning of particular colors can be ambiguous, and even conflicting. Typically, the research on the connotations of colors has presented isolated color samples to the participants and restricted their answers to a limited set of alternatives. Clark & Costall (2008) have decided to adopt a different approach: the participants were asked to imagine their own examples of the target colors. In addition, the semi-structured interviews enabled them to choose their own terms of description. This alternative approach threw light upon more subtle connotations of colors, the multiple meanings of a single color, and also the participants' reasons for these connotations, varying from individual experiences to cultural conventions and stereotypes.

Sixteen students from Portsmouth University took part in the study. The age range varied from 18 to 21 years. The colors implied in the semi-structured interviews were the 11 basic color terms defined by Berlin and Kay: red, orange, yellow, green, blue, purple, black, white, pink, brown and grey. The study confirmed the claim of Levy that cool colors sedate and warm colors provoke active feelings. When questioned about red, most of the participants made comments about love, anger and passion. They emphasized the warmth of the color, using the metaphor of fire. Orange and yellow were also described with respect to temperature but the level of heat significantly decreased. Green and blue were associated with words such as "calm" and "peaceful". Purple was never referred to as "cold" but many participants underlined purple's calming and passive nature. The color black was

depicted a symbol of evil, malice and death. Instead, white was described as the opposite of black. The association of femininity with pink was extremely strong and common. Responses to brown were typically neutral or negative. Grey was also widely regarded as lacking emotion.

The use of color in the Harry Potter series

Color symbolism is consciously used in the creation of a movie. Production designers develop the color palette with respect to the mood of the film. As viewers perceive red, yellow and orange as warm, while blue and green as cool, filmmakers incorporate these colors into sets, costumes and props according to the effect they want to create. In the Harry Potter series, red and green are frequently used to portray good and evil characters. These two colors are opposites on the color wheel and are complementary. In the movies, we have a certain dichotomy between the House of Gryffindor and the House of Slytherin. In fact, Lord Voldemort studied at Hogwarts and he was a Slytherin. In opposition, Harry is sorted in the House of Gryffindor. The two different Houses emphasize different characteristics: Gryffindor is mainly related to the concept of bravery, while Slytherin is associated to the traits of ambition and leadership. This distinction is visually represented through the two emblems: a lion in scarlet and gold, in contrast with a snake in green and silver. Moreover, green is also the color of the killing curse: every murder occurs in dark green light. On the other hand, Harry's spells against Voldemort are red. The result of this clear opposition can be seen in their duels: a red light against a green light, which visually represents the war between good and evil. Another element emphasizes the meaningful use of the color red. In the books, Voldemort has red eyes, but in the movies this characteristic was removed. This signals that red is used for good characters.

The process of gothicization which we have seen, the darkening of the general mood of the movies, is also related to the use of color. However, before getting to that, we must consider that the Harry Potter movies were directed by four different people. Obviously, the four directors associated with the franchise have had a significant impact on the form and style of the movies. Chris Columbus directed the first two movies. He was then replaced by Alfonso Cuarón and Mike Newell, respectively for the third and fourth movie. Finally, the franchise has maintained the same director until the end of the series: David Yates. Each director has brought a distinctive look to the franchise. Columbus' films are the most faithful to the books: they are full of bright colors, magical scenes and centered upon themes such as friendship and love. Cuarón produced a darker and more experimental movie, which feels completely different from the previous ones. Newell decided to maintain the approach established by Cuarón and emphasized it. In the end, Yates continued to reduce the color palette, but also adopted a slower, more contemplative pace, focused on characters over plot.

In the next part, there are several examples that show how the use of colors changes through the series. In particular, I have selected seven case studies in which a certain place in the movies changes as we get to the last installments. The first two examples are focused on the muggle world: Little Whinging, where Harry lives with his uncles, and the city of London. With the third case study, we enter the magical world of Diagon Alley, where wizards from all Britain can buy magical stuff, such as wands and flying brooms. The next three examples present the school: the castle of Hogwarts, the great hall, where the students eat and meet, and the quidditch field, in which they play a magical sport. The last one is centered upon the Burrow, which is the house of the Weasley family.

Part two. Seven case studies

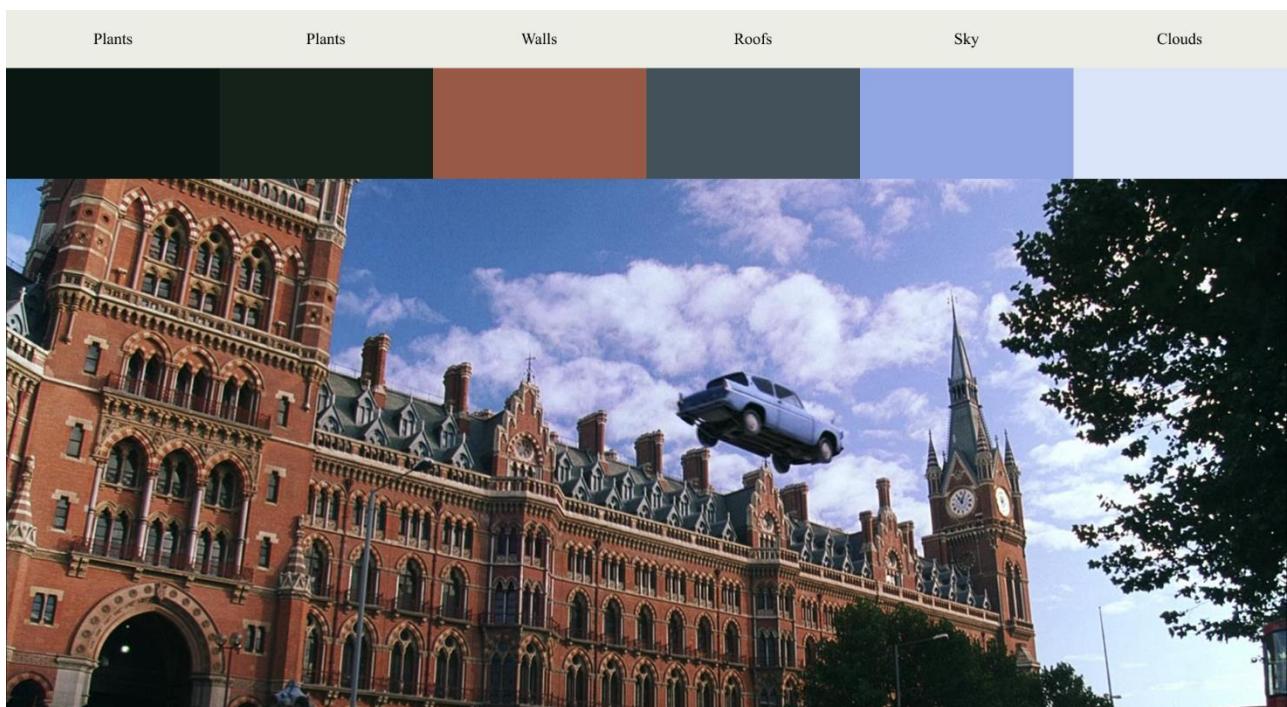
Little Whinging



Little Whinging is the town where Harry lives his infancy. Every year, after school, he has to get back there for summer. However, he never feels at home: he is badly treated by his uncle, aunt and cousin. Harry lives there because his parents were killed when he was just a baby but he is a burden to his kin. Moreover, he's different: he's a magician and they are afraid of him.

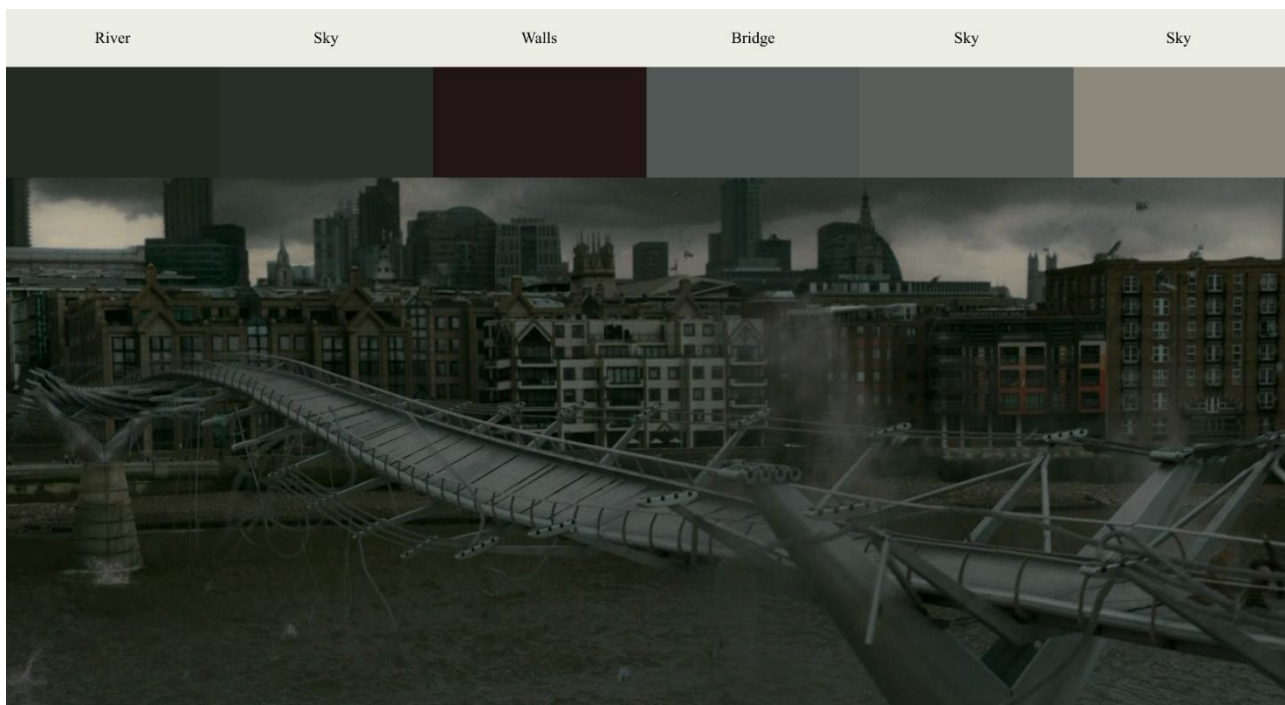
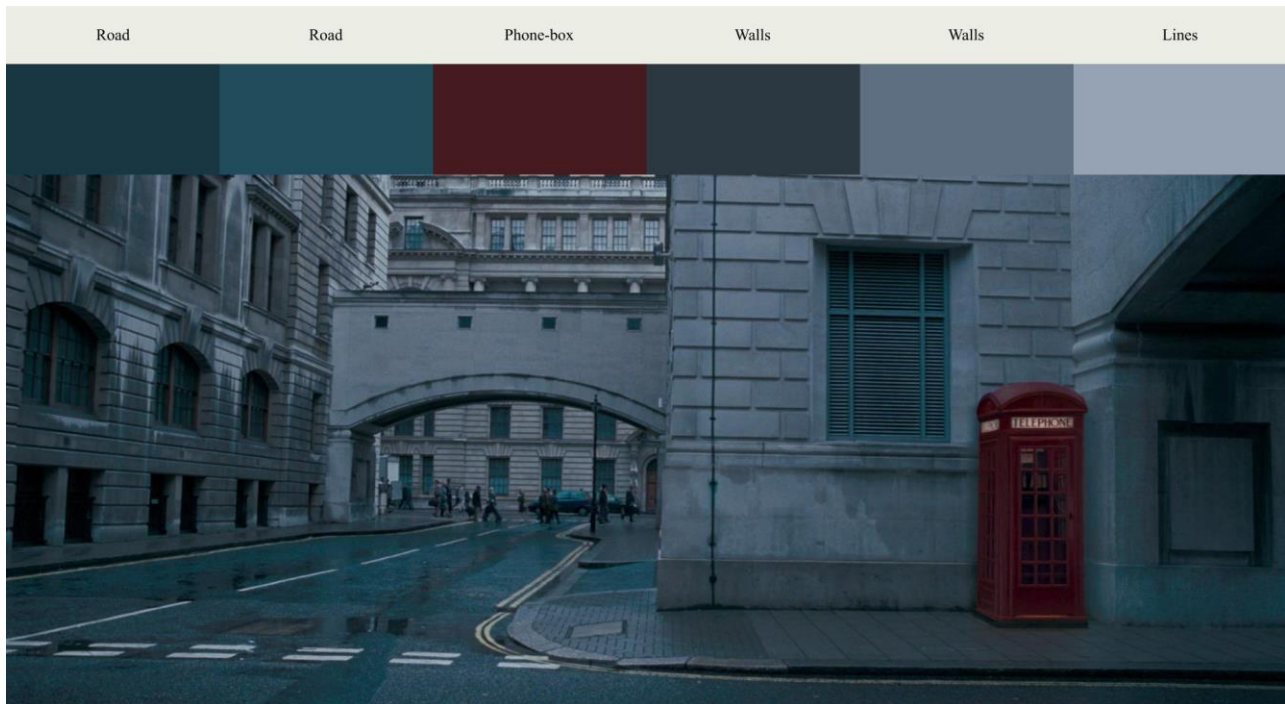
The first image (previous page) is taken from the very beginning, when Harry receives his letter of admission to Hogwarts. Instead, the second one depicts one of the first scenes of *Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows: Part 1* (2010). We can see Harry's uncles leaving their own house because it's not safe for them. The color palette is completely different: the colors adopted for the same roofs and walls change significantly. In the first case, we have the use of brown, while in the second, it's replaced by the color grey. Even the bright green of the grass becomes darker. Most importantly, the sky is completely different: the white sky of the first movie gets cloudy and mysterious.

The city of London



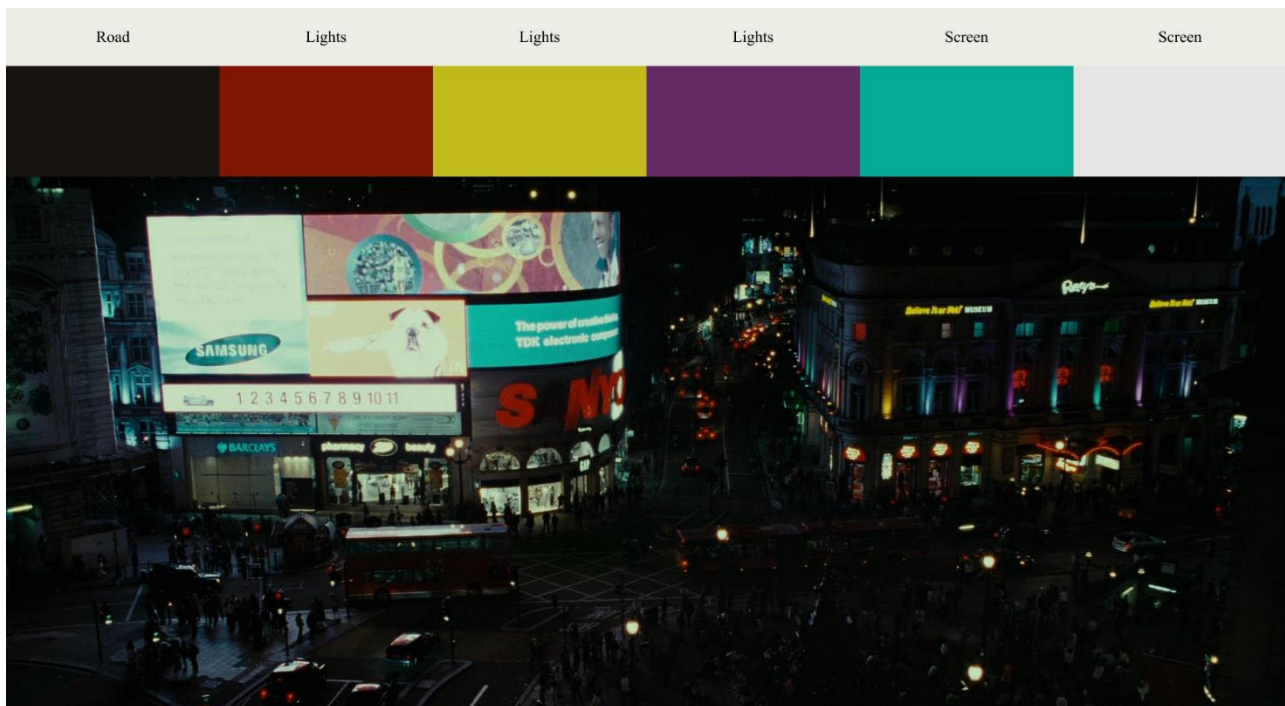
The city of London can be seen several times in the series. The first image refers to the second movie, when Harry and Ron miss the train to Hogwarts and decide to go there with a flying car. The color palette is dominated by the pink walls of the train station. The color blue can be seen in the roofs and in the sky: it's very bright and it gets close to white in the clouds.

In *Harry Potter and the Order of the Phoenix* (2007), London is presented in a completely different way. In fact, if we take a look at the second image (next page), the whole scene is dominated by the grey of the walls. Tints of blue are adopted for the street; in this way, the viewer understands that it has rained. We are far from the colorful image presented above. The only color that emerges from the image is the red of the phone-box. In fact, red is a color that we associate to London: for instance, think about the buses of the city. Without the phone-box, we couldn't understand in which city the scene is set. Moreover, the color immediately directs our attention towards the phone-box, a secret passage that gets Harry to the Ministry of Magic, which is under the city.



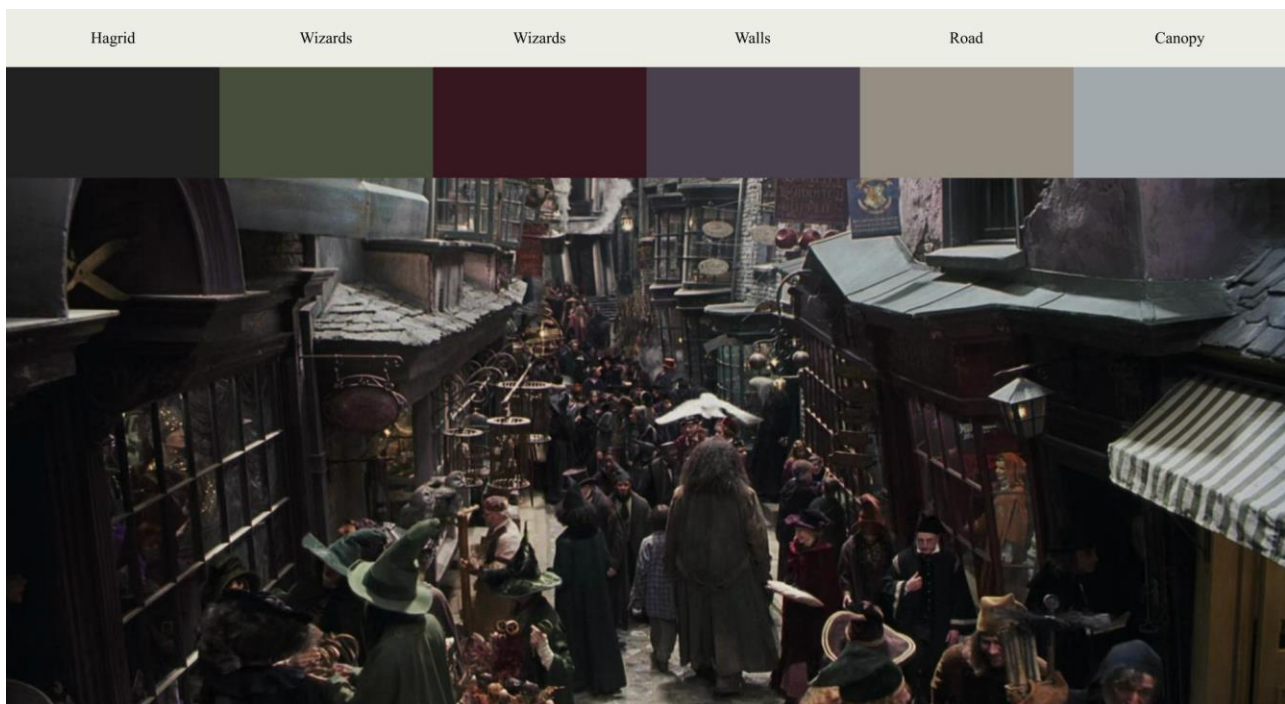
The third image (above) is taken from the opening sequence of *Harry Potter and the Half-Blood Prince* (2009). The very protagonist is the Millennium Bridge, which is a famous place in London. The scene represents a terrorist attack by the Death-eaters, meaning that even the muggle world is in danger. The palette is still dominated by grey but it's certainly darker.

Finally, getting to the last image (next page), we can see London by night. In fact, in *Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows: Part one* (2010), the protagonists are escaping from another assault of the Death-Eaters. Even though the scene is set by night, we can find numerous lights which are very colorful. In particular, we can see these colors: red, yellow, purple, blue and white.

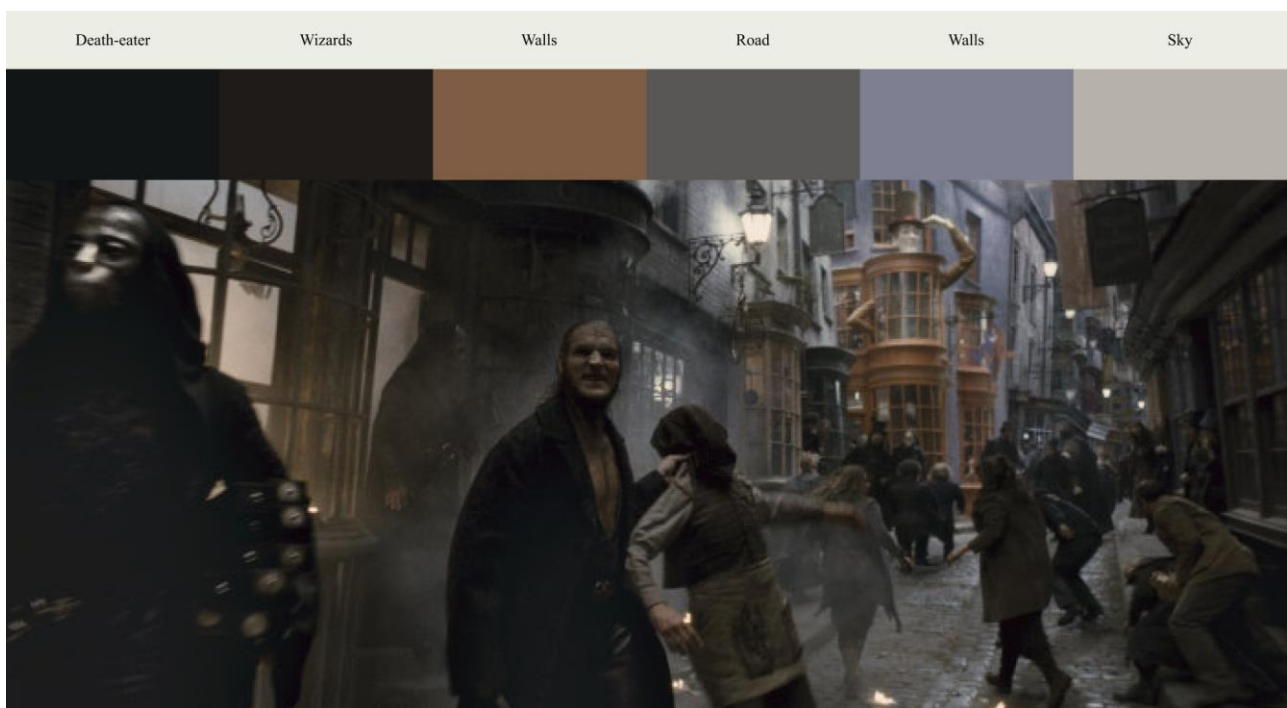


Diagon Alley

With the next two images, we enter in Diagon Alley. The street is full of magical shops, in which Harry goes to buy school stuff. It's the first time in which he gets into this incredible world. It's also significantly important to him because it's where Hagrid gives him the owl Hedwig.

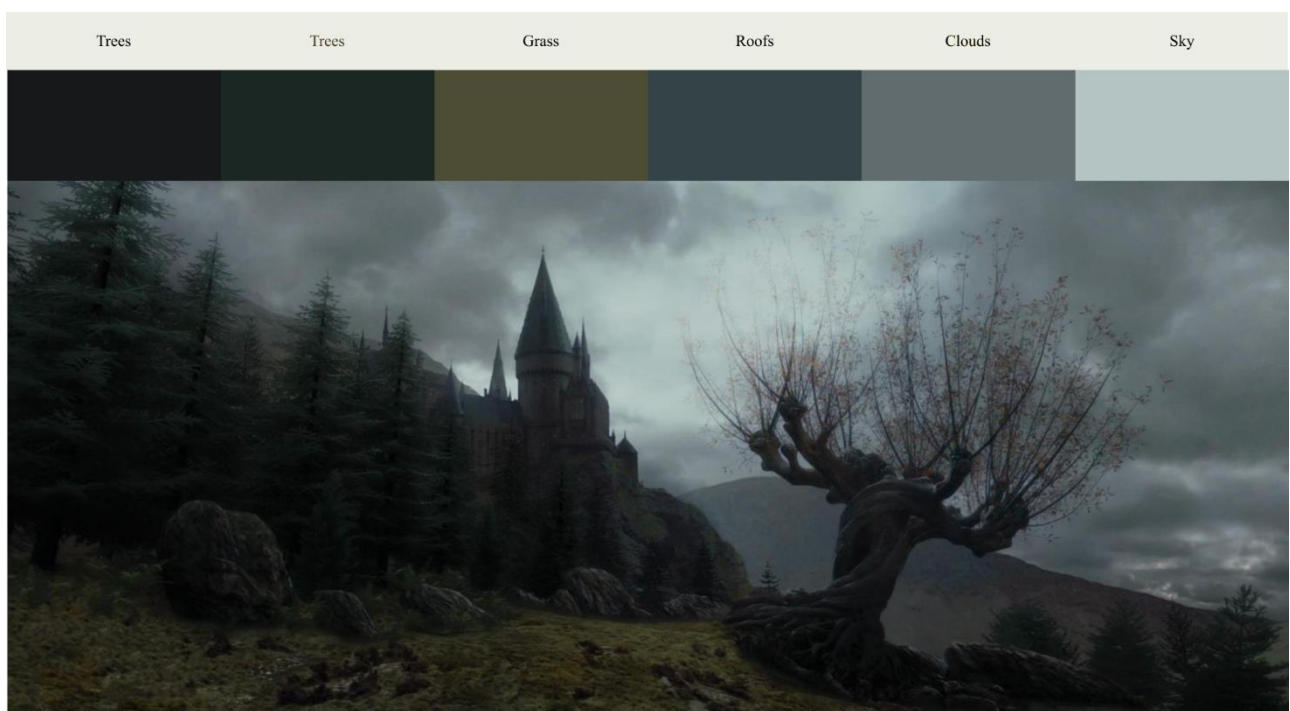
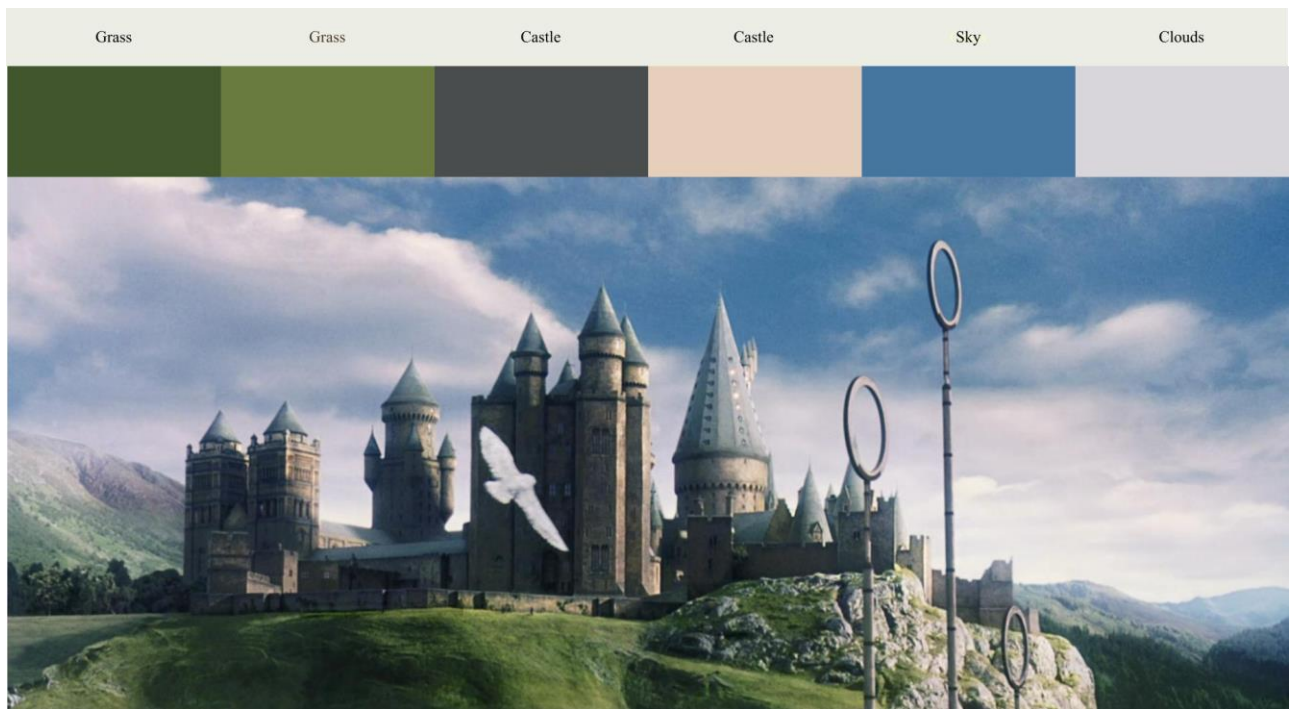


In the first image (previous page), we can see the street of Diagon Alley at the very beginning of the series. It's full of witches and wizards and of course Harry and Hagrid are walking among them. The color palette is quite varied: it goes from dark red to green and purple. Instead, in the image underlying, taken from *Harry Potter and the Half-Blood Prince* (2009), the street is completely different. We are at the beginning of the movie, in the same scene in which the Death-eaters attack the Millennium Bridge. Here, the main protagonist is the werewolf Fenrir Greyback. People are trying to get away from the street; there are screams of fear and smog coming out of Ollivanders. The dominant color is black because our attention is directed towards the Death-eaters. As we can see, the palette is more reduced from the one before, generating a different kind of feeling. In particular, the wizards are dressed in the same colors (mainly black or brown). This shows how the colors adopted for the setting also have an impact upon the costumes worn by the characters.

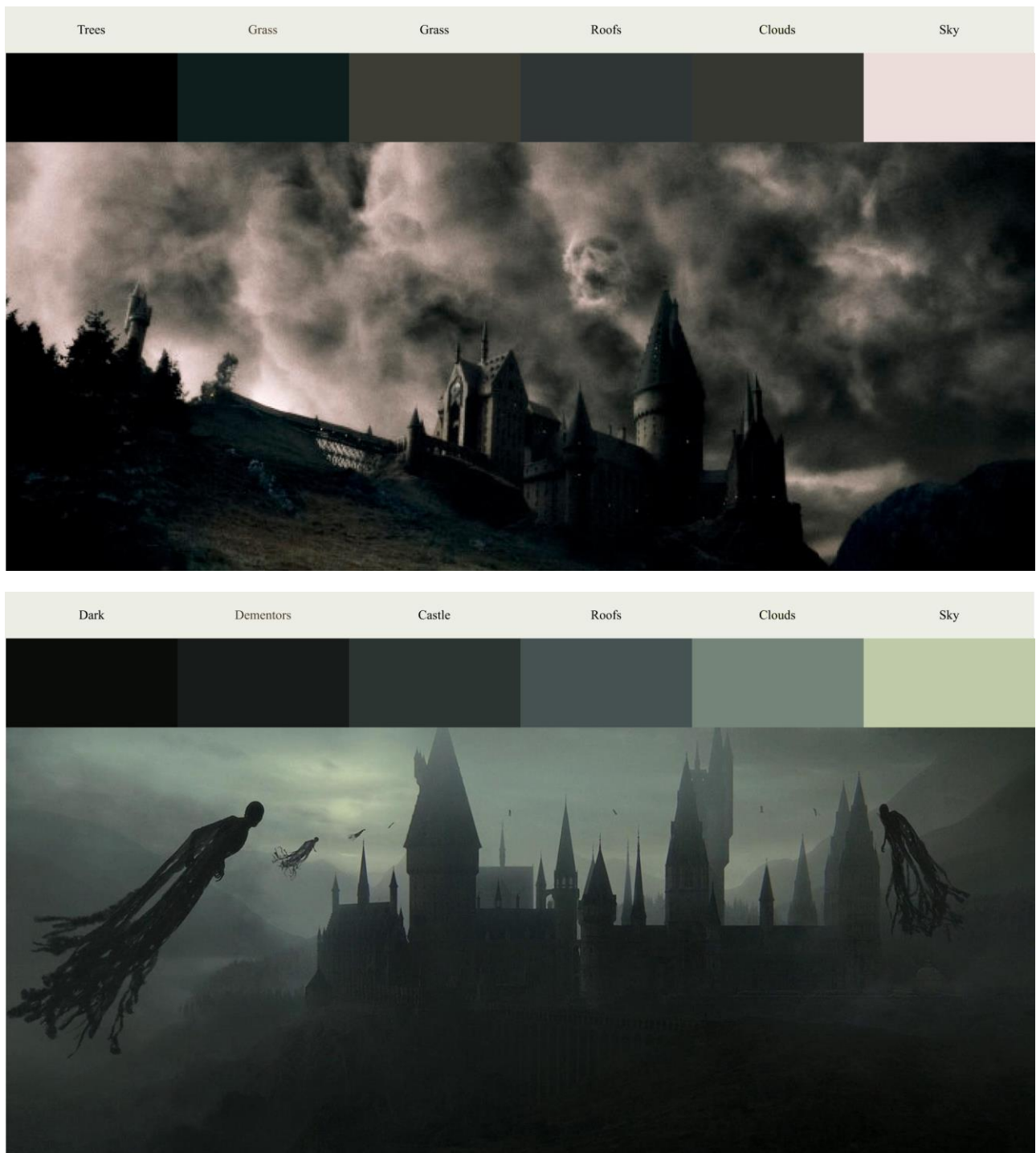


The castle of Hogwarts

The school is the place where Harry feels truly at home. When he gets to Hogwarts he finds friends and begins to follow magical lessons. He discovers that he has good abilities but he always put himself in trouble. The castle is very big and in each movie we get to see new areas, both inside and outside. We are going to analyze four images, starting from the first movie, in which we can see Hedwig flying in the foreground. In the second image, taken from *Harry Potter and the Prisoner of Azkaban* (2004), the sky gets much darker. Then, we switch to the last two images, taken from *Harry Potter and the Half-Blood Prince* (2009) and *Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows: Part 2* (2011).



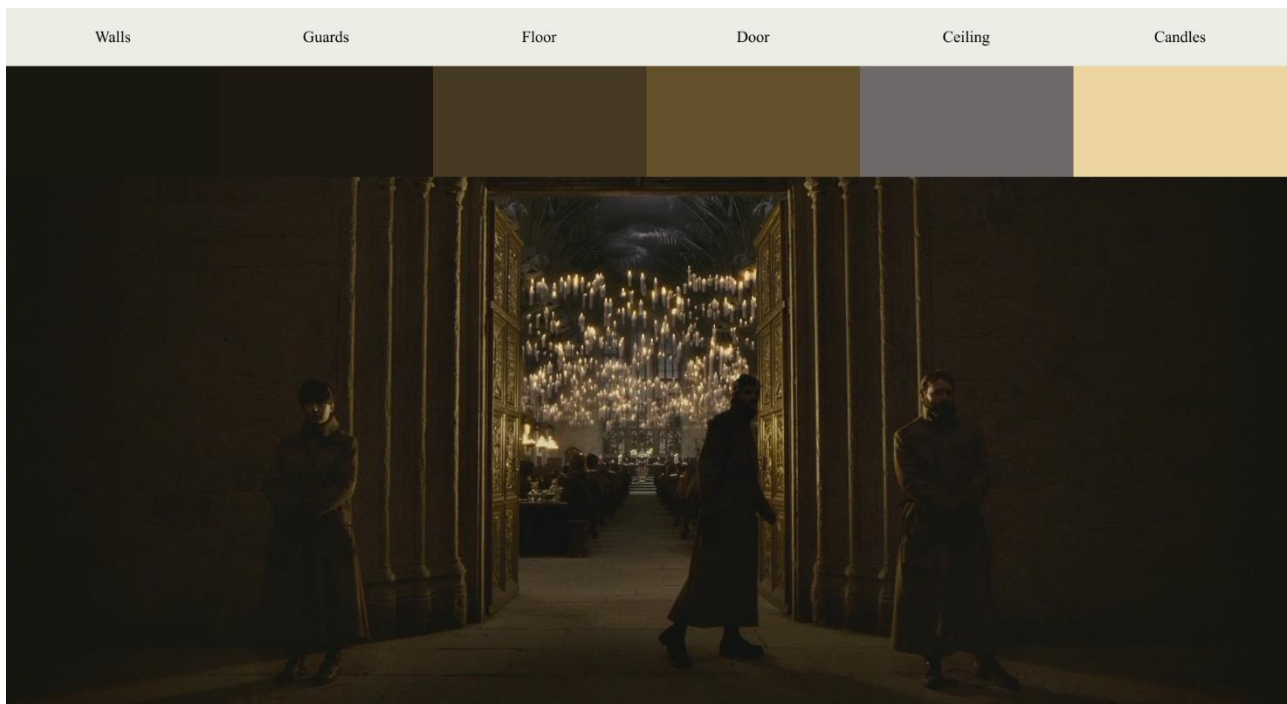
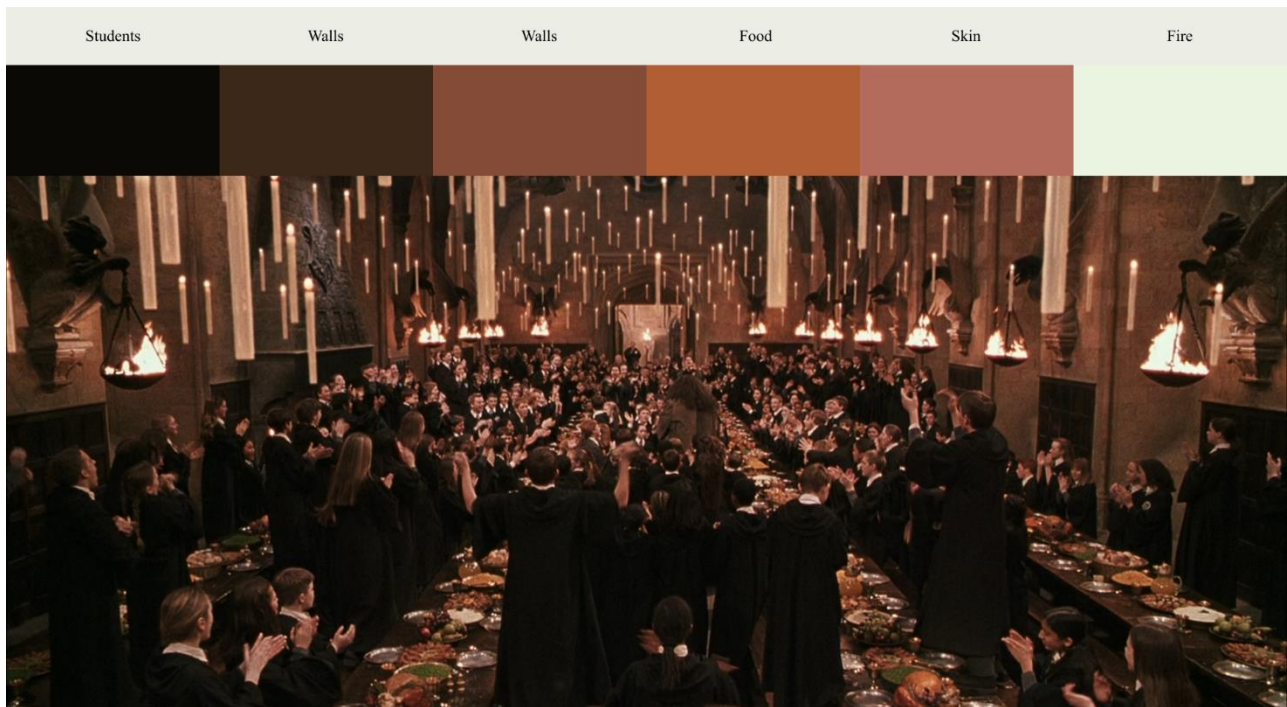
The palette of the first image is very colorful. In particular, we are amazed by the light blue sky and the white clouds. Even the green of the grass is incredibly bright. The walls of the castle vary from grey to pink, in order to create shadows. Instead, in the second image we have a completely different palette. The sky is full of grey clouds, which create a sense of mystery. Even the green of the grass isn't bright as before and the trees to the left add other darker colors. The viewer's attention isn't on the castle itself, which is in the background, but on the Whomping Willow.



The image above is one of the darkest which I have found. It's taken from the ending of the sixth movie, when Dumbledore is killed. The skull that we can see in the sky is the dark mark, symbolizing the passage of the school to the Death-eaters (next movie). We have a different view of the castle, from below, and the palette is dominated by black. However, it's in strong contrast with the white sky. In the last image, we can see the Dementors surrounding the castle. The palette is less dark than before, with the addition of different tints of blue for the fog. The general feeling is that the castle of Hogwarts has surrendered and abandoned all hope.

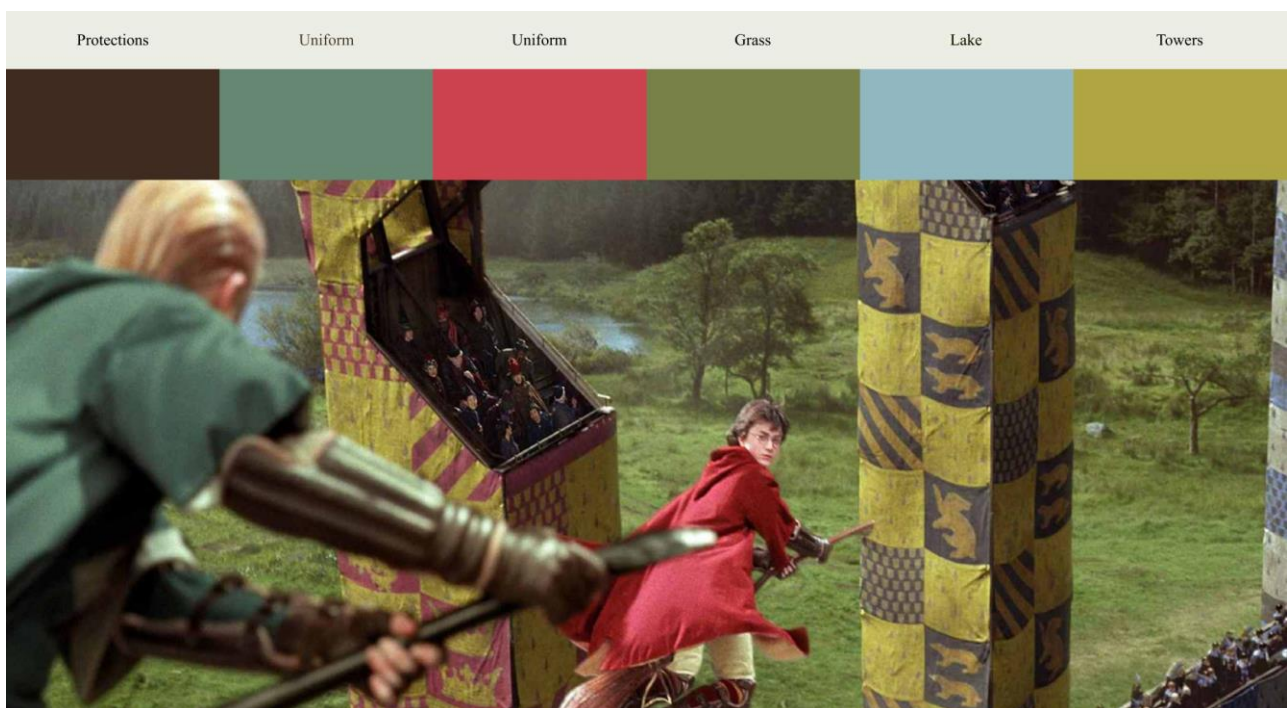
The great hall

Now we get inside of the castle, with the great hall, constituted by four tables, one for each House of the school. The first image is taken from *Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets* (2002), when Hagrid returns to the school after being imprisoned to Azkaban. In fact, we see the students surrounding him and applauding in sign of solidarity. In the second image, taken from *Harry Potter and the Half-Blood Prince* (2009), the great hall is seen from a different perspective.



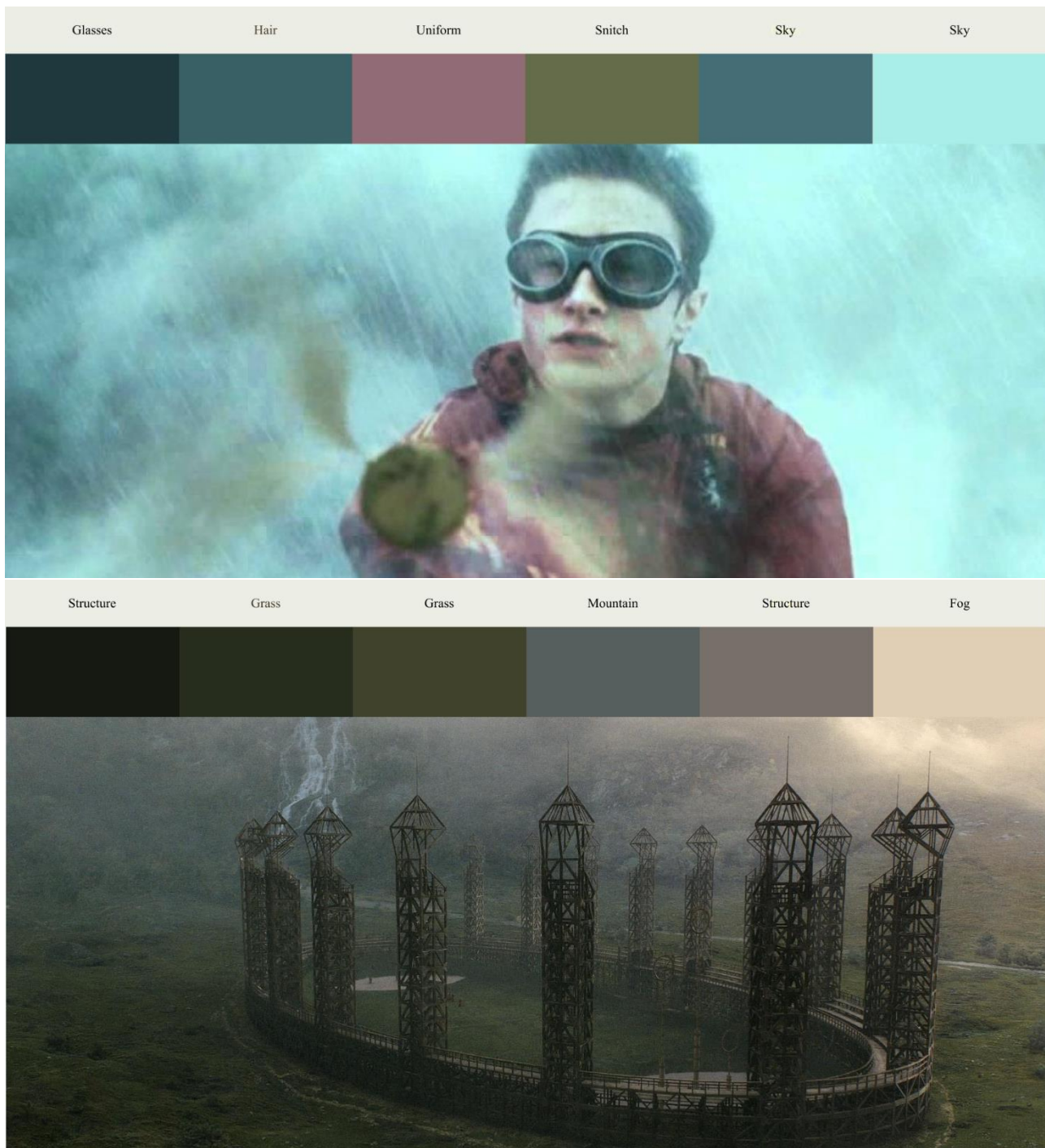
The first image of the great hall (previous page) visually represents the sense of warmth and love of the scene. In particular, this is accomplished by the fire of the lights and candles. The palette is full of colors, starting from the black of the students' uniforms. The walls adopt different tints of brown and if we look at the food we can find other colors, such as orange and green. These warm colors vanish in the second image, where the attention is on the guards in the foreground. In particular, there are shadows that don't allow us to see the walls. The light comes from the candles in the great hall but it's weaker than before. In fact, the contrast between the black foreground and the white candles isn't strong. We also have this blue ceiling which adds a sense of cold to the image.

The quidditch field

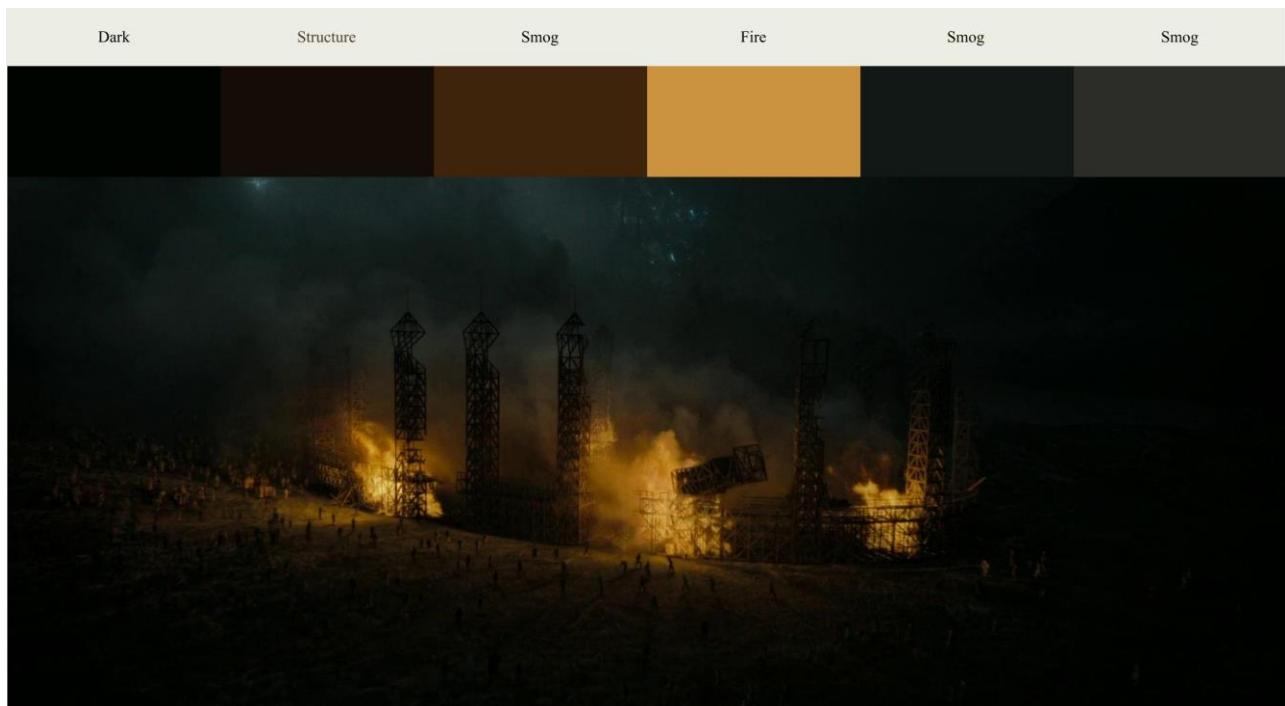


Another external place of the castle is the quidditch field, in which the students play this magical sport flying on their brooms. In the image above, taken from the second movie, we can see the match between Gryffindor and Slytherin. The colors of their uniforms, red and green, attract the viewer's attention. The green of the grass is bright as the one that we have already seen outside of the castle. We also have these yellow towers where people can watch the game.

In the second image (next page), taken from *Harry Potter and the Prisoner of Azkaban* (2004), we have a close-up on Harry. The scene is completely different because there's a storm during the match. The colors are evidently colder. In particular, we have a vast use of blue, especially the one that we see in the sky, which tends to white. Harry's uniform is different too: it's less bright.

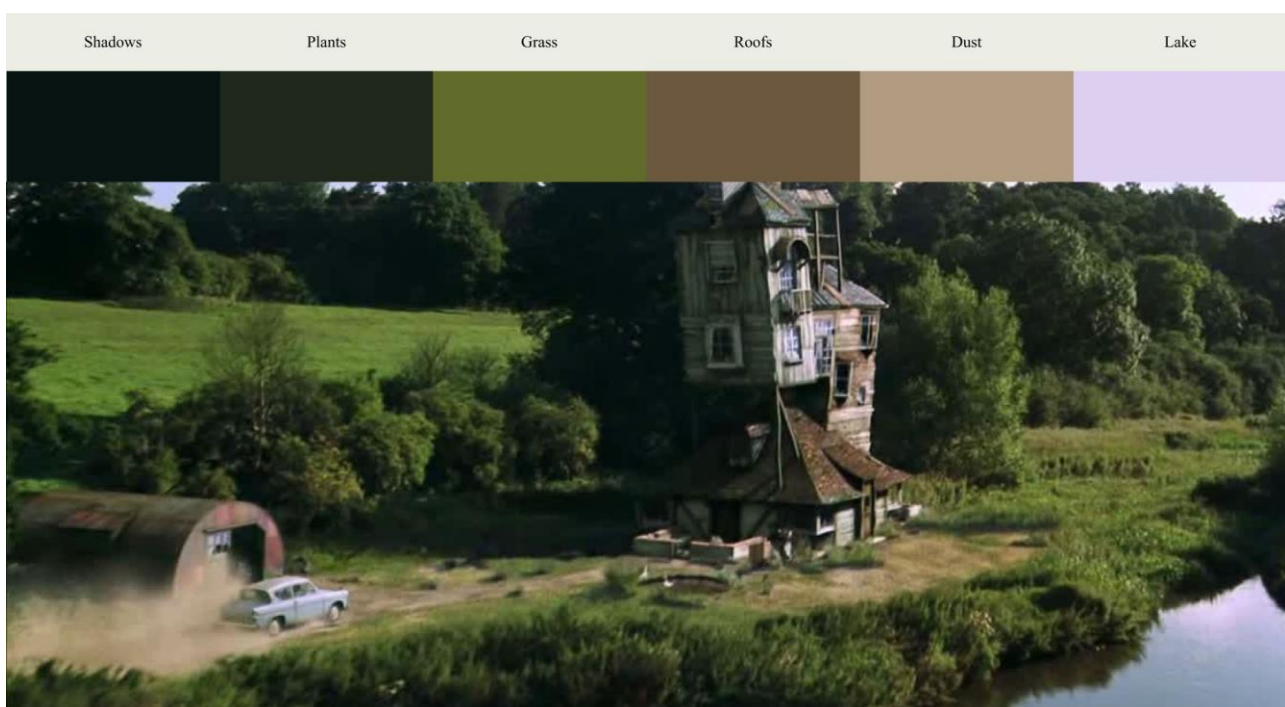


The image above is taken from *Harry Potter and the Half-Blood Prince* (2009). The external sequences of this movies are always dominated by the use of fog. Visually, the colors adopted are mainly blue and grey, while the color of the grass is darker with respect to the first image. Getting to the last movie (next page), we see the quidditch field by night for the first time. Death-eaters are attacking the castle and they burn the place down. In particular, black is the main color adopted. We can see only few details, thanks to the fire that illuminate the grass. There's smog coming from the towers and we can see these soft blue lights in the background, which come from the castle.

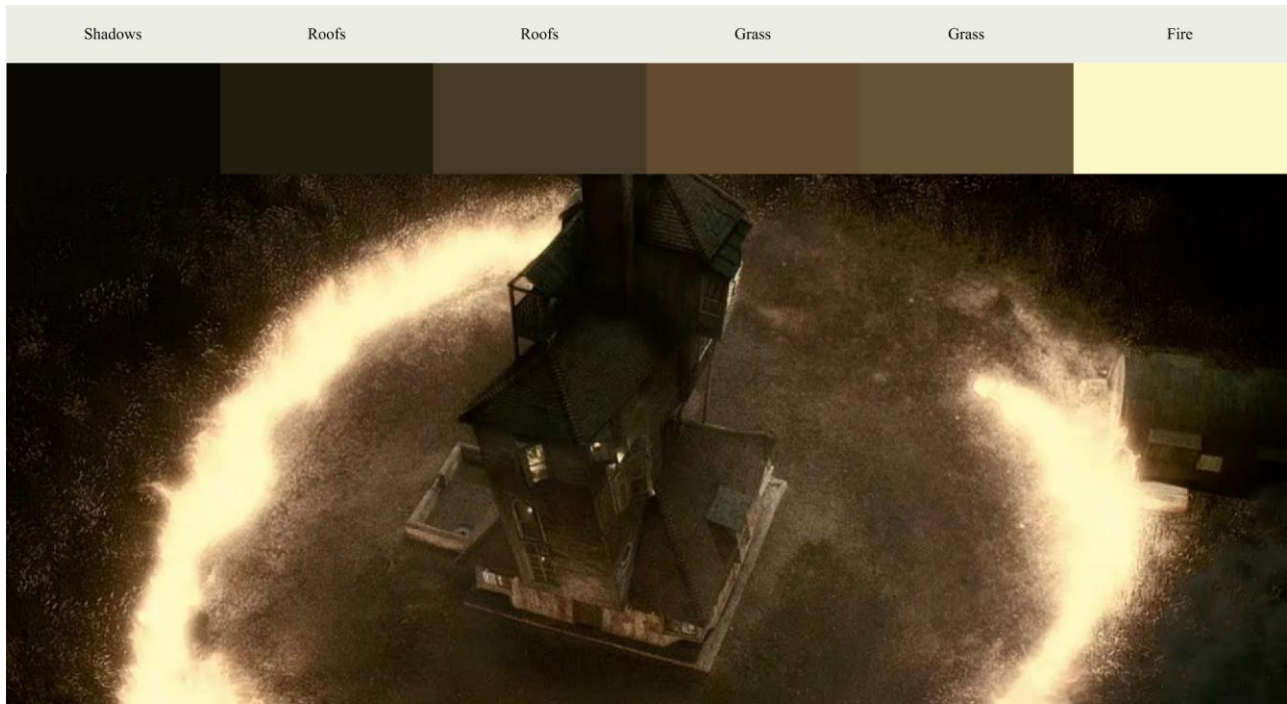


The Burrow

With the last example, we move away from Hogwarts in order to analyze another magical place. The Burrow is the family home of the Weasley family. It's made of wood and it has a particular structure. The image below is taken from *Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets* (2002), while the second image (next page) is taken from *Harry Potter and the Half-Blood Prince* (2009).



The first image (previous page) represents the Burrow in a sunny day. The dominant color is green but we also have these bright reflections in the lake. Even the brown dust is particularly light. This kind of palette is very similar to all those that we have seen with respect to the first two movies, directed by Christopher Columbus. Instead, if we look at the image below, we have a smaller palette with powerful contrasts. In particular, black and brown are in clear opposition to the white flames that surround the place. Again, as we have seen with the castle, black and white visually represent the fight between good and evil. This darkness creates a sense of threat to the viewer. In the scene, the Death-eaters attack the house, which at the end is completely destroyed.



Conclusion

As we have seen, there is a process of gothicization that takes place in the Harry Potter series. A process which involves the story, with the introduction of monsters and beasts. The plot gets darker: as Harry and his friends grow up, they must face increasingly difficult challenges. However, this transition is also linked to the different directors of the movies. In particular, we have noticed a significant change from the first two movies and the third, directed by Alfonso Cuarón. This gothicization process can be fully understood looking at the color palettes. In particular, there are two considerations to be made: first of all, the color palettes get smaller as we move towards the last installments. The images taken from the first movies have a greater number of colors, while the images taken from the last movies have fewer colors. Secondly, the predominant colors at the beginning are warm colors, such as red, orange and yellow. Getting to the last movies, they are gradually replaced by cold colors: in particular, there's a significant use of grey, blue and white.

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